

EUROPE

THE SMALL CONTINENT of Europe has been covered by ice at least four times in the past million years. The climate in northern Europe is still very cold and many birds from this region migrate south for the winter.

Europe does not have a huge variety of bird species, partly due to the cold weather in the north, but also because of the large numbers of people that live there—many more than in North America. People have cleared away the forests, polluted the

land and water, and hunted the birds. Birds that cannot live in cities, parks, or yards have been driven to remote areas such as mountains, moorlands, and marshes. Many coastal habitats in Europe are, however, very rich in bird life. Estuaries provide vital feeding and resting areas for waterbirds and waders migrating south from the Arctic. Sea cliffs are home to nesting colonies of seabirds such as gannets, guillemots, puffins, and razorbills.

Europe under ice

At various times in Earth's history, there have been cold spells called ice ages, each lasting for thousands of years. During an ice age, ice sheets and glaciers spread across Earth's surface. Over the past 900,000 years, there have been about 10 major ice ages. At the height of the last ice age, about 18,000 years ago, huge ice sheets spread out from the North Pole, covering much of Europe. Some birds died out, while others moved south to warmer places. About 11,000 years ago, the climate became warmer again, the ice receded, and some of the birds returned north.



This map shows the extent of the ice sheet 11,000 years ago—at the end of Europe's last ice age.

Climate and landscape

The climate of Europe ranges from the cold, rainy, and snowy northern lands, such as Scandinavia, to the hot, dry Mediterranean lands of the south, such as Italy and Greece. In the middle are warm, wet areas with a mild climate. A warm ocean current called the Gulf Stream flows from the Caribbean past the western shores of Europe, making the winter climate on the west coast less severe. Europe's landscape includes long mountain chains, such as the Alps and the Pyrenees, which can interrupt the movement of birds from north to south.

AMAZING BIRDS OF EUROPE



Goldcrest
(*Regulus regulus*)

Smallest bird

The tiny goldcrest and its cousin the firecrest are the smallest European birds.

Fastest bird

The peregrine falcon is the fastest bird in the world. It reaches speeds of up to 112 mph (180 kph) when swooping down to chase its prey.

Long legs

Second only to flamingos, the black-winged stilt has long legs in relation to the length of its body. It can feed in very deep water.

Varied eggs

Guillemots have one of the widest varieties of colors and patterns on their eggs. This allows parents to recognize their own eggs on the crowded cliff ledges where they nest.

Largest clutch

The female gray partridge lays the most eggs at one time of any bird—as many as 15–19 eggs in one clutch. She lays so many because a large proportion of the chicks do not survive.

Marvellous mimic

The marsh warbler can imitate the calls of more than 200 other bird species.

Greatest stamina

The common swift spends more time in the air than any other land bird. It can sleep, eat, and drink while in flight, at heights of up to 6,500 ft (2,000 m).



Swift
(*Apus apus*)



Many people live and farm in the sunny Mediterranean region, growing trees such as these olives. This means there are fewer places for birds to live.